

lot of doors. But once you are out of the bank, it's different," she says. Admitting it was a "rude shock," she says even for the government, she represented SBI Cap and not SBI. Nothing deterred her, though, and she used the stint as a training ground.

Bhattacharya says one should always take a chance to head an organisation regardless of its size. "It is an invaluable lesson you can never get even if you are a managing director. Unless you are the chairman, it is not possible."

THE BIG ONES

In October 2013, Bhattacharya moved into the corner office at SBI. The best was yet to come. Reaching the pinnacle is a proud moment, though she is a little philosophical about it. "It is a little lonely and, therefore, it is important to keep your friends close. Many people will tell you what you want to hear but you must have a close set of friends to tell you the truth," she says. Growing into the role also meant being open-minded. Bhattacharya narrates how one of her managing directors gave her handy advice. "When you start a conversation or bring up a point, you must be the last one to speak. If you speak first, the others may not have an opinion."

"If someone has a view on a subject, I should be open-minded enough to listen to it. And if that view is reasonable, I must change my stance," she says.

These skills were put to good use during SBI's merger with five associate banks and Bharat Mahila Bank. She says it was not a popular decision; the team was not too comfortable with the move. "It was a huge task and these six banks together would have been bigger than the second largest at that point in time. You were merging a really big bank into yourself, and that too in six pieces, all in one day," she says.

There was more than one sound rationale for the merger. Bhattacharya says it did not make sense for one entity to own six banks. "We were undercutting each other. There was duplication at many lev-

THE JOURNEY

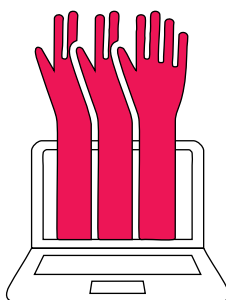
01 **A post graduate in English literature, Bhattacharya rose to the top at SBI**

02 **The turning points in her career include a stint in the US and heading SBI's new businesses**

03 **As SBI Chairman, two of her biggest achievements were the bank's merger with its subsidiaries and the digital foray**

04 **Under her, SBI pursued discipline and became a formidable force with a solid balance sheet**

05 **At Salesforce, she has taken up a new challenge in an area where she has had no prior experience**



els." An example: three floors in a multi-storied building occupied by three banks belonging to SBI.

Bhattacharya recollects hearing about the possible merger when she joined the bank. That was decades ago. "I thought it was time and went for it," she says. Ensuring that the customer faced no hitches was important. Bhattacharya recalls one person who had an account with State Bank of Mysore and used internet banking on the day of the merger. "He wrote to me that the experience was seamless and was very pleased with the outcome."

According to Deepak Parekh, former Chairman of HDFC, SBI has had a history of competent chairmen. "A lot of credit must go to the training system and the way promotions and deputations are decided. The grounding you get there is among the best in the country," he says. Bhattacharya was the first woman to hold the top job at SBI. Parekh says under her leadership, SBI pursued discipline and became a formidable force, most evident in impressive financial numbers and high stock price. "Credit was given only when there was a strong case. Arundhati is a very strong person and has always stood her ground," he says.

Parekh says the challenge must be viewed in the context of manpower issues and subsidiaries not doing well. "Plus, they existed in different geographies with their own culture. That entire process, with many challenges, was handled in an exemplary manner," he adds.

Another big challenge was demonetisation, which Bhattacharya calls a "googly." At 2:30 PM on November 8, 2016, she got a call from the RBI deputy governor's office for a meeting. The heads of other banks also joined, and it became apparent that something big was unfolding. "Ultimately, we got to know about it with the rest of the nation," she says. She focused her attention on execution and working with a cool head.

The other focus was digital. "The power it brought to the table and the ability to do things in an error-free manner